

Week 9 — Diagnosis by Hearing & Smelling

聞診

EAM310 · EAST ASIAN MEDICINE DIAGNOSIS I · VUIM SUMMER 2026

⚠ Quiz 6 — September 11, 2026

Class: Friday September 11, 2026 · 9AM–1PM

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REQUIRED READINGS — DUE BEFORE SEPTEMBER 11

FCM CHAPTER 26 — MACIOCIA

- Diagnosis by Hearing & Smelling — full chapter
- 聞 Wén — same character means both "hear" and "smell"
- Hearing: voice, breathing, cough, vomit, hiccup, borborygmi, sighing, belching
- Smelling: body odour + odour of bodily secretions
- General rule: Loud=Full · Weak=Empty · Foul=Heat · Absent=Cold

SCHRIER LECTURE SLIDES — WK 9 FILE

- Voice-Zang Fu relationship (Lung/Kidney/SP-ST)
- Five Element sounds — detailed clinical descriptions
- Six Healing Sounds (Qigong) — bonus/supplementary
- Five Element odors — sensory descriptions with pinyin
- Odors of nose, ears, eyes — supplementary to FCM

WEEK 9 LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Apply the general hearing rule: loud=Full/Heat, weak=Empty/Cold
- Map the 5 voice sounds to their organs (shout/laugh/sing/weep/groan)
- Differentiate Full vs Empty presentations of cough, hiccup, belching, vomiting
- Interpret odor of breath, sweat, sputum, stool, urine, vaginal discharge
- Apply the general smelling rule: foul=Heat, absent=Cold
- Map the 5 body/breath odors to their organs (rancid → putrid)
- Interpret abnormal respiration (asthma, wheezing, panting, SOB)
- Recognize when body-odor/constitution mismatch is a worse prognostic sign

ASSESSMENT CALENDAR

Date	Event	Material Covered
Sep 4	Week 8 Class	Diagnosis by Inquiry (cont.) + Palpation
Sep 11	⚠ Quiz 6	Diagnosis by Hearing & Smelling — voice, sounds, odors
Sep 18	FINAL + Journal 26–50	Weeks 6–9 comprehensive

IN-CLASS PRACTICE — WHAT TO EXPECT

LISTENING & SMELLING PRACTICE LAB

Week 9 includes partner practice on auditory/olfactory diagnosis. Come ready to:

- Listen to a partner's speaking voice — assess volume, Five-Element tonal quality
- Practice distinguishing loud vs weak sounds across cough, breathing, belching
- Discuss body odor as a constitutional Five-Element indicator (non-invasive, verbal report is fine)
- Document a case in your Journal integrating hearing/smelling findings with tongue/pulse

聞 Wén — the same Chinese character means both "to hear" and "to smell." Both are used together as ONE of the Four Diagnostic Pillars.

DIAGNOSIS BY HEARING — WHAT WE LISTEN FOR

First — listen to changes in	Speech and breathing; volume, strength, clarity, and rate
Second — listen for	"Abnormal" sounds: coughing, sneezing, belching, etc.

General principle: A LOUD sound indicates a Full/Heat pattern. A WEAK sound indicates an Empty/Cold pattern. This single rule underlies all of listening diagnosis — voice, breathing, cough, vomiting, hiccup, borborygmi, and more.

VOICE — ZANG-FU RELATIONSHIPS

Organ	Relationship to the Voice
Lung	The gateway of the voice — helps create sounds through the movement of Qi. The <i>production</i> of sound is directly related to this organ.
Kidney	The root of the voice — controls the root of Yuan Qi and the reception of Qi. The <i>volume</i> of the voice is directly related to this organ.
Spleen & Stomach	The acquired root of Qi — influences vocalization. The <i>strength</i> of the voice is directly related to these organs.

VOICE — QUICK REFERENCE

Loud voice	Full or Heat pattern
Weak voice	Empty or Cold pattern
Weak and vague	Exterior Wind-Cold, or Dampness
Reluctance to talk	Cold pattern or Lung-Qi deficiency
Excessive talking	Heat
Sudden loss of voice	Invasion of exterior Wind-Heat
Gradual loss of voice	Lung-Qi or Lung-Yin deficiency

ABNORMAL VOCALIZATIONS — HOARSENESS

Sudden onset, low pitch, raspy	Exterior syndrome
Chronic, gradual intensity	Blood stagnation
Hoarseness + plum-pit sensation + cough	Phlegm-Heat
Chronic, gradually increasing, worse in evening	Lung and Kidney Yin deficiency

FIVE ELEMENT SOUNDS — MASTER TABLE

Sound / Element	Clinical Description
Shouting 呼 hū / Wood	Gives forcefulness to the voice; an indication of assertion. When one shouts they want to be heard and/or are asking, explicitly or implicitly, for changes to be made. Frequently becomes louder at moments when the person is not really needing to be assertive.
Laughter 笑 xiào / Fire	Occurs when expressing moments of joy. Does not necessarily mean an actual belly laugh — can include a "pre-laugh" without an actual laugh emerging. Fire is a very Yang Element, so just as laughter rises upwards/outwards, so does this sound.
Singing 唱 chàng / Earth	May occur naturally when singing a lullaby with a child in arms, or soothing an anxious/distressed animal or person. Has increased variation in pitch — the voice goes up and down more frequently.
Weeping / Metal	Consumes or dissolves Qi. More of a non-verbal sound, based on an expressive emotional quality. When a person speaks with a weep they might easily begin to cry; other times there could be a choking back or faltering in the words.
Groaning / Water	Has little movement or modulation in quality — a flatness, as if the more normal ups and downs of the voice have been squeezed or flattened out.

Clinical use: These are not just diagnostic labels — listen for HOW a patient speaks, not just what they say. A patient who shouts unnecessarily during a calm conversation reveals Liver disharmony independent of their words.

VOICE & ZANG-FU — QUICK MATCH REFERENCE

Shouting	Liver / Wood
Laughing	Heart / Fire
Singing	Spleen / Earth
Weepy	Lung / Metal
Groaning	Kidney / Water

USING SOUNDS AS HEALING — THE SIX HEALING SOUNDS 六字訣

A Qigong practice using specific sounds/breaths to affect corresponding organs — supplementary context for how the diagnostic sounds connect to therapeutic sound.

噓 Xū	Affects the Liver — helps remove Heat, disperses blockages, brings brightness to the eyes
呵 Hē	Affects the Heart — expels Heat, makes Qi descend, reduces Fire in the Heart
呼 Hū	Affects the Spleen — helps drive out Heat and strengthens the Spleen in all four seasons
咽 Sì	Affects the Lung — moderates stress, calms Qi, moistens the Lungs
吹 Chuī	Affects the Kidneys — removes Wind and Cold, urges stagnant Qi, brings tranquility
嘻 Xī	Affects the Triple Burner — clears Heat and restlessness, drives out strong emotional afflictions

BREATHING — QUICK REFERENCE

Coarse, loud breathing	Full pattern
Weak, thin breathing	Empty pattern
Deep breathing	Excess Qi in the Heart and Lungs
Weak breathing	Deficiency of Qi in Liver and Kidney
Rough respiration, rapid inhalation, slow exhalation	Heat, excess, exogenous condition
Faint respiration, slow inhalation and exhalation	Deficiency condition or chronic internal condition

RESPIRATION — EXCESS VS EMPTY PATTERNS

Pattern	Presentation
Excess and/or Heat patterns	Sound of respiration is loud, breath rough and distressed, acute onset. Seen in surplus of external contraction of pathogenic factor or Phlegm-Heat invading the Lung.
Empty and/or Cold patterns	Sound of respiration is low, breath faint and slow, disease onset relatively slow. Seen in internal damage causing insufficient Zheng Qi and Kidney/ Lung-Qi vacuity.

PANTING — EXCESS VS DEFICIENCY

Rapid, irregular respiration, extreme to the point that the nostrils move, with uneven entrance/exit of breath, opening of the mouth, raising of the shoulders, and difficulty lying down.	
Excess	Respiration irregular, chest is full, sound is loud, breath is rough, exit of breath is irregular and exhalation uneven — Xie Qi (pathogenic Qi) obstructing the Lung
Deficiency	Respiration irregular, breath timid, voice low, inhalation diminished and exhalation increased, breath not continuous, panting more severe with movement — Kidney deficiency (unable to absorb Qi) or Lung deficiency (unable to govern Qi)

ABNORMAL RESPIRATION — BY TYPE

Asthma	Lung-Qi's failure to descend
Wheezing	Lung-Qi fails to descend with Phlegm obstruction
Upper Stifling	Lung-Qi rises upward to the throat and obstructs the air tract
Shortness of Breath	Lung-Qi deficiency, or Water Retention in the Chest (coughing up watery sputum)
Shortage of Qi	Lung-Qi obstructed, Lung-Qi deficiency, or Zheng Qi insufficient

COUGH 咳嗽 KÉ SÒU

Due to the Lung not diffusing and down-bearing, Lung-Qi rising counterflow, and Phlegm and Qi flooding the airways.

Loud, explosive cough	Full pattern
Weak cough	Empty pattern
Dry cough	Lung-Yin deficiency
Sound without phlegm	"Unproductive cough"
Phlegm with sound	"Productive cough"

SNEEZING

Acute onset, constant loud sounds	Heat and/or excess condition
Chronic, frequent, soft in volume	Lung-Qi deficiency
Sudden sneezing in critical stage of chronic illness	Yang-Qi recovery
Sneezing due to external stimulation	Normal

VOMITING, HICCUP & BELCHING

Type	Full/Excess	Empty/Deficiency
Vomiting	Sudden onset, retching loud/forceful — frequently Stomach-Heat	Slow onset, retching low/faint/without force — frequently Stomach deficiency and Cold
Hiccup	Loud sound — often Liver-Qi invading Stomach	Quiet, low sound — often Stomach-Qi or Stomach-Yin deficiency
Belching	Loud and long sound — retention of food, Stomach-Heat, or Liver-Qi invading Stomach	Short and low sound — Stomach-Qi deficiency or Stomach-Qi deficiency with Cold

VOMITING, BELCHING & HICCUP — ALL REBELLIOUS STOMACH-QI

Symptom	Mechanism
Vomiting	Food, fluid, or sputum flows up from the Stomach and out of the mouth with sound
Belching	Air or gas flows up from the stomach and makes sound passing through the throat
Hiccup	Stomach-Qi's rebellion causes involuntary spasms of the diaphragm and makes a short sound

BORBORYGMI (GURGLING SOUND IN THE INTESTINES)

Loud sound (usually with diarrhea/dysentery)	Full pattern — Cold-Damp in Middle Burner, Phlegm-Damp in MB, Liver/Spleen disharmony, or Damp-Heat in Stomach & Intestines
Low sound	Empty pattern — Spleen/Kidney-Yang deficiency, or Middle Burner Qi deficiency

YAWNING

Frequent, loud, relieved after yawn, induced by emotional changes	Liver-Qi Stagnation
Accompanied by chest pain, may occur after injury or chronic illness	Blood and Qi Stagnation
Infrequent attack, weak or no sound	Spleen/Kidney-Yang Deficiency

SIGHING

Generally indicates Qi stagnation of the Liver or Lungs , often from emotional problems
Liver involved: repressed anger or frustration
Lungs involved: worry and sadness
Weak sound sighing may also be due to deficiency of the Spleen and Heart, deriving from sadness, grief, or pensiveness

Integration principle: Borborygmi, yawning, and sighing all follow the same Full/Empty logic as every other hearing-diagnosis sign — but each carries a distinct organ signature (Intestines/SP-KD for borborygmi, LV-Qi stagnation for yawning, LV/LU-Qi stagnation for sighing). Cross-reference with the patient's emotional history for confirmation.

DIAGNOSIS BY SMELLING — TWO ASPECTS

First	The odor of the patient's body itself — gives insight into both the pattern of disharmony AND the patient's constitutional type
Second	The odor of certain bodily secretions — used only to identify the prevailing pattern of disharmony

General rule: Any strong and/or foul smell is indicative of **Heat**. Absence of smell is indicative of **Cold**. Smelling is not usually a clinching diagnostic factor — mostly used to confirm the main pattern already suspected from other signs.

BODY ODOR — CONSTITUTIONAL VS PATHOLOGICAL

Body odors are detected mostly when the patient undresses, especially on the back
In the absence of a disharmony, body odor reflects the patient's constitutional Five-Element type
Body odor can ALSO reflect current patterns of disharmony — which may NOT match the patient's Element type

Key clinical principle: If body odor CONTRADICTS the constitutional Element type, this is a BAD sign. It is WORSE for a Wood type to have a scorched (Fire) odor than an exaggerated rancid (Wood) one — the mismatch reveals a disharmony outside the person's own baseline organ system.

FIVE-ELEMENT ODORS — DETAILED SENSORY REFERENCE

Odor / Element	Sensory Description
Rancid 餿 sōu / Wood	Associated with fat that's no longer fresh or slightly sour; related to newly mown grass but not pleasant. Effect on the inside of the nose is somewhat prickling, makes one wrinkle their nose.
Scorched 焦 / Fire	Resembles burnt toast, clothes just out of the tumble dryer, or a shirt scorched while ironing.
Fragrant/Sweetish 香 xiāng / Earth	NOT a pleasing floral smell — the opposite. More associated with a cloying, sickly-sweet quality with a tendency to linger in the nostrils.
Rotten 爛 làn / Metal	Fills the inside of the nose with tiny prickles, may make one clench the inside of their nose. Rotting meat / trash can / garbage truck is the best verbal description.
Putrid 腐 fǔ / Water	The smell of rotting meat; can also describe stagnant pond water or stale urine. Has a sharp, aggressive quality that makes one's nose clench up.

HEAT VS COLD — GENERAL ODOR CHARACTER

Heat or Excess	Foul, rotten, fetid, stinking
Cold or Deficient	Fishy or odorless

BODY ODOR — SPECIFIC PRESENTATIONS	
Goatish odor	Wind, Damp, Heat accumulation
Foul stinking	Epidemic infectious disease, or Summer-Heat toxin
Foul set in the armpit	Damp-Heat accumulation
BREATH	
Strong, foul	Stomach-Heat or retention of food
Sour	Retention of food; Accumulation Disorder (in children)
Foul, pungent	Damp-Heat in Stomach and Spleen
Rotten	Damp-Heat in Large Intestine (may be ulcerative colitis)
Fishy	Phlegm-Heat in Lung
SWEAT	
Sweat's smell is related to Dampness — fluids forming sweat come from the space between skin and muscles, where Dampness often accumulates.	
Strong-smelling	Damp-Heat
Putrid-smelling	Disease of the Lungs, Liver, or Kidneys
SPUTUM	
Strong-smelling, often rotten	Heat in the Lungs — usually Phlegm-Heat or Toxic Heat
Fishy-smelling	Lung-Heat
Without smell	Cold
STOOL & FLATULENCE	
Extremely stinky, foul, diarrhea + pus/blood	Damp-Heat in the Intestines
Sour + foul + indigestion	Food stagnation
Fishy odor + loose stools	Cold in Spleen/Stomach
Slight/odorless flatulence, aggravated by emotional stress	Liver-Qi stagnation
Flatulence rancid, rotten like rotten eggs	Toxic Heat in the Large Intestines
Abnormal stool color, but without odor / frequent odorless flatulence	Stomach/LI-Qi deficiency
URINE	
Frequent, urgent, painful, burning, turbid yellow + foul odor	Damp-Heat in Bladder
Heavy smell of urea, scanty yellow urine	Heart-Fire pouring into Bladder
Clear, frequent, odorless (or slightly fishy)	Kidney deficiency
Odorless urinary incontinence	Exhaustion of Kidney-Fire
VAGINAL DISCHARGE & NOSE/EARS/EYES ODORS	
Strong, leathery vaginal discharge	Damp-Heat
Fishy vaginal discharge	Damp-Cold
Strong-smelling lochia (post-childbirth)	Damp-Heat or Toxic Heat in the Uterus
Nose: yellow sticky discharge, foul odor	Heat in Lung, or Damp-Heat in Spleen/Stomach
Ears: foul, fishy odor + turbid pus/discharge	Damp-Heat in the ear
Eyes: red/swollen + turbid tears + foul/fishy odor or ulceration	Damp-Heat in the Liver channel

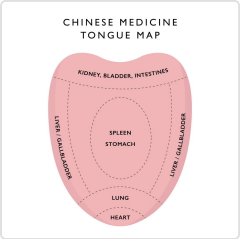
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ETIOLOGY	ORGAN SYSTEM	DATE

CLINICAL ESSENTIALS — CASE NOTES

HEARING & SMELLING 聞診

CHINESE MEDICINE TONGUE MAP



VOICE / BREATH / SOUND / ODOR

PULSE 脈診 · CUN · GUAN · CHI

Wrist	CUN 寸	GUAN 關	CHI 尺
L HT/SI		LV/GB	KD/BL
R LU/LI		SP/ST	PC/TB

QUALITY / OVERALL

TREATMENT PRINCIPLE 治則

KEY POINTS / HERBS

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